

Designing the hero: copy, image, and call-to-action together

Week 6, Lecture 2, Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

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What we will cover

- Headline writing for designers: why word count is a layout decision
- The subhead as proof: one sentence that answers "why you?"
- CTA design: button copy, fill, padding, and surrounding whitespace
- Hero imagery: product screenshot, illustration, or abstract background
- Putting it together: a live hero critique

By the end of this lecture you can compose a hero section where the headline, subhead, CTA, and imagery each do their specific job at the right visual weight.

Part 1: the headline

A headline is a layout decision before it is a copy decision

A seven-word headline fits on one line at 64px and dominates the page. A twenty-word headline forces a smaller size or awkward line breaks.

- Short headline: maximum visual weight, design freedom
- Long headline: lower visual weight, risk of three-line wrap at medium viewports

The implication: write your headline before you start the layout. Measure it in your type scale. A headline that fits cleanly at your h1 size with good line breaks is a better design candidate than a cleverer headline that wraps badly.

Write three variants. Pick the one that says the most in the fewest words.

What makes a headline work

The one rule: state a specific outcome for a specific customer.

"Ship faster" is not a specific outcome. It is a direction.

"Ship your first feature in a day, not a sprint" names:

- A specific customer action (ship a feature)
- A specific time claim (one day)
- A specific contrast (not a sprint)

The specificity does two things: it tells the right customer they are in the right place, and it gives every other element on the page a concrete claim to support (Segall 2023).

Headline writing: patterns that work

Four headline patterns used by high-converting SaaS pages:

1. **Outcome contrast:** "Ship in days, not months." Names the before and after.
2. **Audience + outcome:** "For engineering teams that are tired of status meetings." Names the customer and the pain.
3. **Specific claim:** "Cut sprint planning time by 60%." Measurable. Memorable.
4. **Question that the product answers:** "What if your backlog planned itself?" Creates a curiosity gap.

Pattern 4 is the riskiest. If the question is too vague, visitors disengage. If it is specific, it is more engaging than a statement.

The subhead as proof

The subhead has one job: answer the implicit question the headline raises.

If the headline says "Ship your first feature in a day, not a sprint," the implicit question is "how?" or "why should I believe that?"

The subhead answers in one sentence. It should not restate the headline. It should advance it.

Weak (restates)	Strong (advances)
"A project management tool for modern engineering teams"	"Built for teams that batch deploys, not meetings"
"The fastest way to manage your backlog"	"AI fills empty sprints from your backlog before you open the app on Monday"

Wathan and Schoger (2019): use format and context to communicate meaning before you add a label. The same principle applies to the subhead. It earns its space by doing something the headline cannot do alone.

Part 2: CTA design

The four CTA design decisions

Every CTA button has four design decisions that together determine whether it reads as the primary action on the page.

1. **Copy:** generic vs. specific action
2. **Style:** filled vs. outline
3. **Padding:** touch-safe sizing on an 8-point grid
4. **Surrounding whitespace:** isolation vs. embedded in a group

Getting all four right takes thirty minutes in Figma. Getting only one right still produces a weak CTA.

CTA copy: specific action over generic label

Generic copy names nothing about what happens next.

Generic	Specific
Get started	Start your 14-day trial
Learn more	See a live 5-minute demo
Sign up	Build your first page free
Try it	Run your first report

The specific version reduces anxiety: the visitor knows what clicking commits them to. It also converts better because it aligns with the outcome the headline promised (Wathan & Schoger 2019).

CTA style: filled, not outline

An outline button signals a secondary action. A filled button signals the primary action.

- Use your primary accent color (the 500-600 step in your color ramp from Week 4)
- No other interactive element in the hero should share that color
- If your navigation links, secondary CTAs, or any decorative element uses the same hue, the button's visual singularity disappears

Schoger (CSS Day 2019) demonstrates this in the first makeover: switching a gray outline button to a filled blue button doubles the visual hierarchy without changing a single word.

CTA sizing on an 8-point grid

Button height on a 1440px desktop:

```
Minimum (touch-safe):    48px = 12px font + 18px padding top + 18px padding bottom
Standard primary CTA:    56px = 16px font + 20px padding top + 20px padding bottom
Horizontal padding:      32px = 4 grid units minimum
```

The button should read as second in visual weight after the headline. Measure it: if the button looks as heavy as the headline, reduce padding or reduce the button's fill intensity. If the button looks lighter than the body copy, increase the fill intensity or increase padding.

CTA surrounding whitespace

Whitespace around the CTA is the most underused lever for CTA visibility.

A button at 8px from the nearest element reads as part of a group. The same button at 48px reads as the primary action on the page.

Test: toggle your layout grid off and look only at the CTA. Can you tell it is the most important interactive element? If not, add whitespace before you change the color.

Schoger's CSS Day makeovers (2019) consistently show that whitespace isolation improves CTA clarity more than color change alone.

Part 3: hero imagery

The imagery question is about evidence, not aesthetics

Choosing between a screenshot, illustration, or abstract background is a question about what evidence the visitor needs to clear the "what is this?" threshold.

- **Screenshot:** strongest evidence for product quality
- **Illustration:** best when the core value is abstract or the UI is not yet finished
- **Abstract background:** correct only when copy alone is sufficient

The wrong choice is not ugly. It is a missed opportunity to answer the visitor's question faster.

Product screenshot: strengths and rules

A real product screenshot is the strongest form of social proof in a hero because it cannot be faked with stock imagery.

When to use it:

- The UI is clean enough to be self-explanatory at reduced size
- The product is in a category where visitors need to see before they believe
- Your competitors use illustrations (differentiation)

Rules for using a screenshot:

- Reduce opacity to 80-85% so the copy retains visual dominance
- Add a border-radius (8-12px) and a subtle drop shadow so the screenshot reads as a contained object, not a background element
- Crop to show the most persuasive 20% of the UI, not the full interface

Illustration: when it earns its place

Use an illustration when the product's core value is abstract and a screenshot of the UI would not communicate that value.

Examples where illustration is correct:

- A product that coordinates workflows between multiple tools (a flowchart illustration explains the relationship better than a screenshot of any one tool)
- An early-stage product where the UI is incomplete
- A concept product where the value is a methodology, not a feature set

Rules: the illustration style must match the brand voice (see Week 3, typeface voice). A detailed technical illustration and a geometric sans-serif headline are compatible. A hand-drawn sketch and a modern grotesque are not.

Abstract background: the default of last resort

Use an abstract background (gradient, texture, or decorative pattern) only when copy alone is sufficient.

Most products have a UI or a concept worth showing. A gradient with no imagery communicates "we couldn't decide what to put here" unless the product operates in a genuinely abstract domain.

When it works: a service product, a consulting offering, or a framework where any visual would be misleading. Even then, a pattern background with the right copy is better than a background that fights the headline.

Part 4: putting it together

The hero checklist

Before you call a hero section done:

- ☐ Headline: 10 words or fewer, names a specific outcome for a specific customer
- ☐ Subhead: one sentence, advances the headline (does not restate it)
- ☐ CTA copy: specific action, not generic label
- ☐ CTA style: filled, using primary accent color
- ☐ CTA padding: 48-56px height, 32px horizontal, on 8-point grid
- ☐ CTA whitespace: 48px of clear space above and below the button
- ☐ Imagery: opacity at 80-85% (screenshots), or illustration that matches brand voice
- ☐ Hierarchy: toggle grid off and confirm eye lands on headline first, CTA second

A live critique: before and after

Before

After

- Headline: 24px, semi-bold, "The best way to manage your team's work"
 - Subhead: 16px, regular, "Collaborate, track, and ship with confidence"
 - CTA: outline gray, "Get started," 8px from subhead
 - Hero image: 100% opacity screenshot, more visual weight than headline
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- Headline: 56px, bold, "Ship your sprint backlog in half the time"
 - Subhead: 20px, regular, "Built for teams"

What changed and why

Each change addresses a specific diagnosis from the five-point framework:

- **Headline size:** increased from 24px to 56px to establish visual dominance. A 24px headline at the same size as the subhead has no hierarchy signal.
- **Headline copy:** replaced a category description with a specific outcome. "Best way" is unverifiable. "Half the time" is a claim the visitor can evaluate.
- **CTA style:** filled replaces outline. Outline signals secondary. Filled signals primary.
- **CTA whitespace:** 48px above and below moved the button from embedded-in-group to primary-action-on-page.
- **Image opacity:** reduced from 100% to 80% to return visual dominance to the copy column.

Take-aways

1. A headline is a layout decision: its word count determines which type sizes are available. Write three variants and measure each one in your scale before you commit.
2. The subhead has one job: advance the headline, not restate it. Answer the implicit question the headline raises.
3. CTA design has four dimensions: specific copy, filled style, correct 8-point padding, and 48px of surrounding whitespace. All four must be right.
4. Product screenshots are the strongest hero imagery because they are the most direct evidence of product quality. Use them at 80-85% opacity with a contained frame.
5. The hero checklist is a specification, not a checklist of preferences. Every item has a design reason.

"Your label tells the user what they will get. If the context around the control already makes that clear, adding the label is clutter, not clarity."

Adam Wathan & Steve Schoger, *Labels Are a Last Resort*, Refactoring UI (2019)

What's next

- **This week, section:** Hero-section critique: tear down and rebuild three real SaaS heroes using the five-point framework from this lecture
- **HW3 (out this week):** Design a full landing page for your product in Figma. All five sections, on an 8-point grid, using your type scale and color ramp from weeks 3-4.
- **Reading:** Week 6 reading at </c/design-for-builders-26au/readings/wk06>
- **Week 7:** App UI: screens, states, and component systems

